

Business Ethnography - Curriculum Design

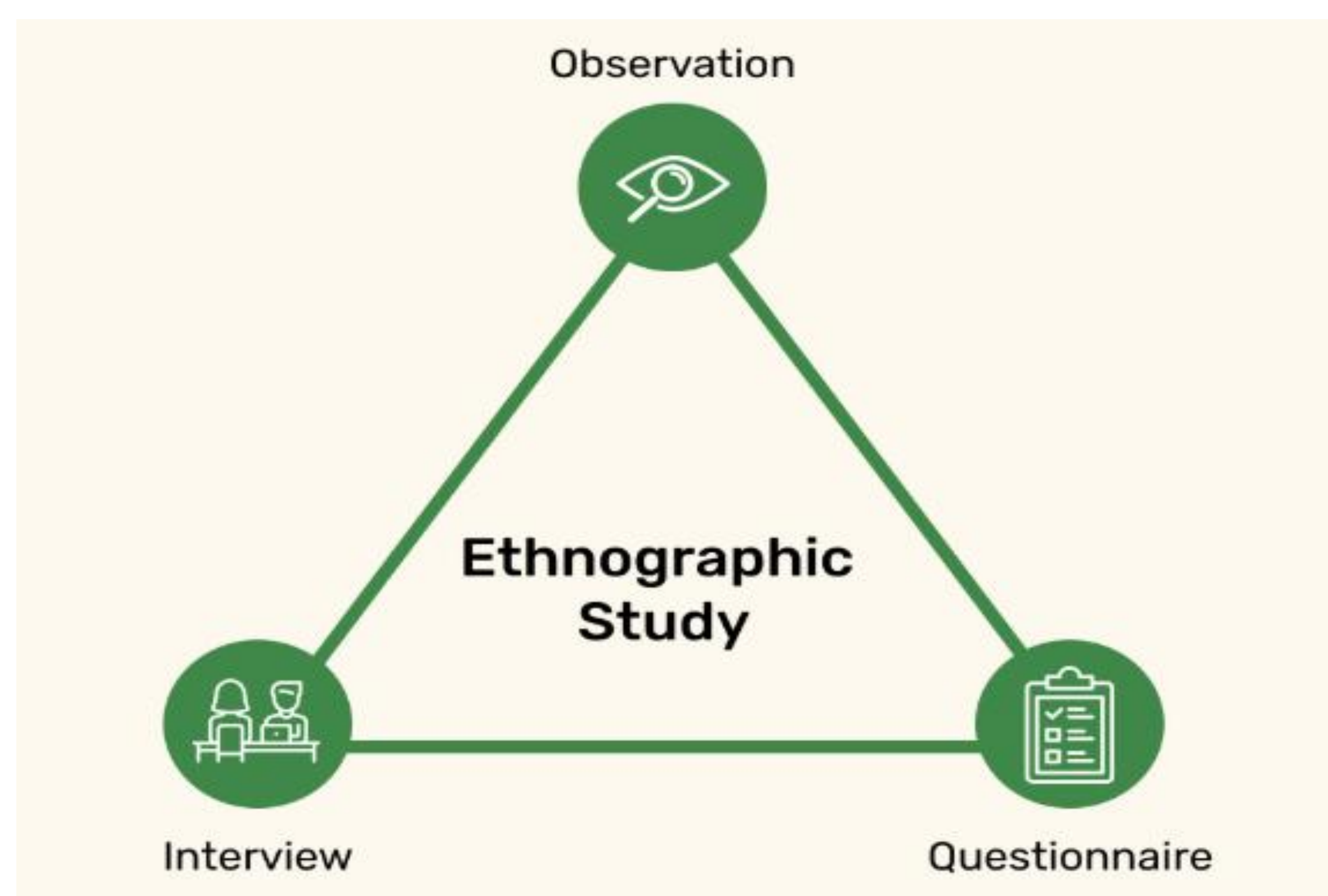
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Course Description

Business Ethnography applies anthropological research methods such as participant observation, in-depth interviews, and cultural analysis to understand the behaviors, values, and decision-making processes of people within business contexts. By bridging anthropology and business, this course explores how businesses can leverage ethnographic insights to address real-world challenges like consumer behavior, organizational culture, and product development. Students will learn how ethnography uncovers the deeper social, emotional, and cultural factors that influence interactions with brands, services, and organizations, providing valuable insights for marketing, innovation, and workplace design. The course will also focus on ethical considerations when conducting business ethnography and examine the ways anthropological methods can be applied to improve business practices in a global, diverse, and evolving marketplace.

Keywords/ Core Ethnographic Methods

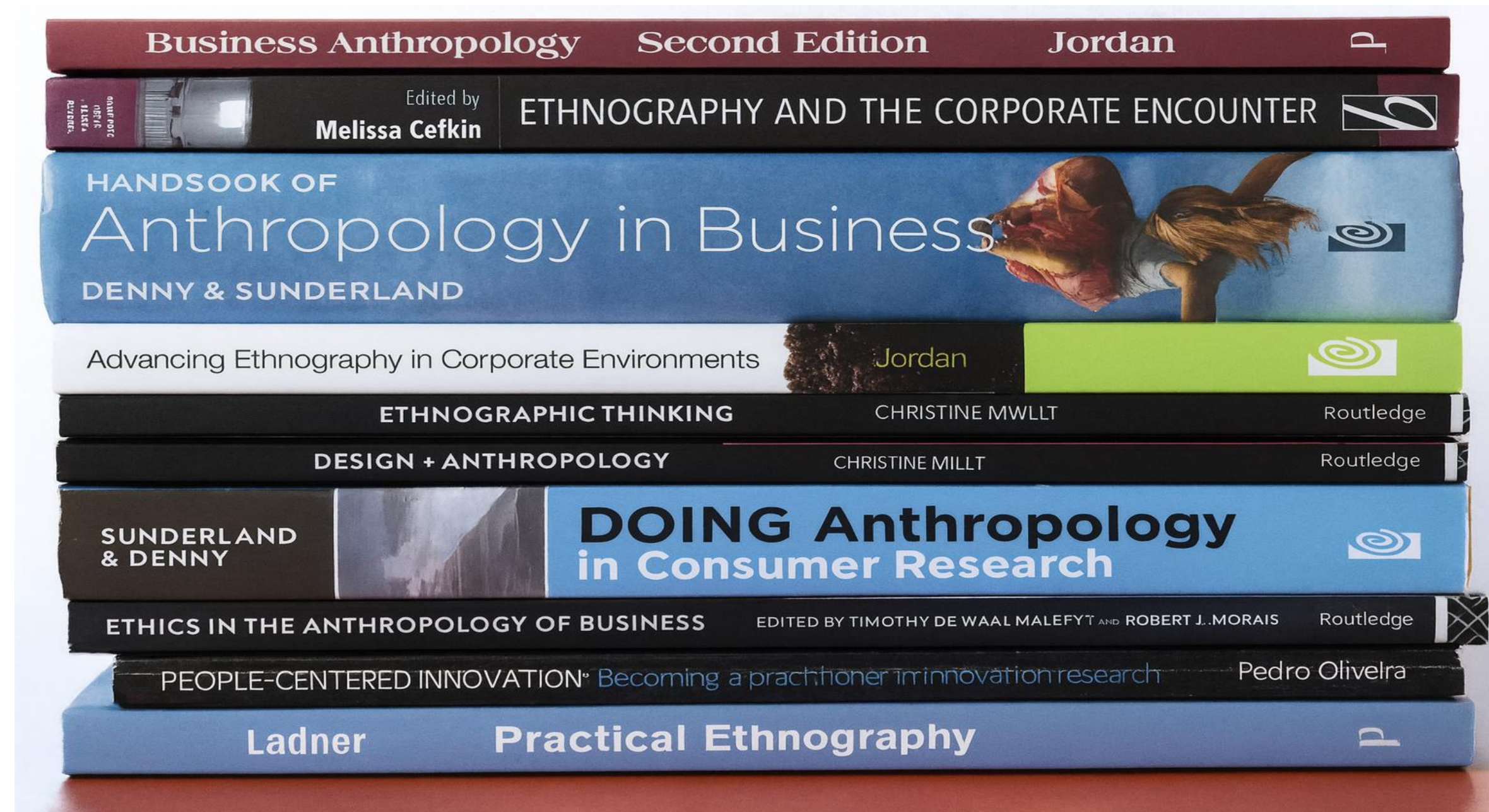
- **Participant Observation-**
Involves immersing oneself in a setting to observe and record behaviors, interactions, and rituals as they naturally unfold.
- **Fieldnotes & Reflexive Journaling-**
Fieldnotes involve documenting detailed observations, while reflexive journaling includes recording personal reflections and interpretations to better understand the research process.
- **Reflexivity-**
Involves reflecting on your own role, biases, and influence as a researcher throughout the ethnographic process to ensure self-awareness and transparency.
- **In-depth Interviews-**
In-depth interviews are one-on-one conversations that allow participants to share detailed insights into their experiences, perceptions, and beliefs on specific topics.
- **Cultural Context-**
Refers to understanding behaviors and interactions within the framework of the specific cultural, social, and historical environment in which they occur.



How observation, interviews, and questionnaires work together as the three pillars of an ethnographic study to capture rich, holistic insights

3 Guiding Questions

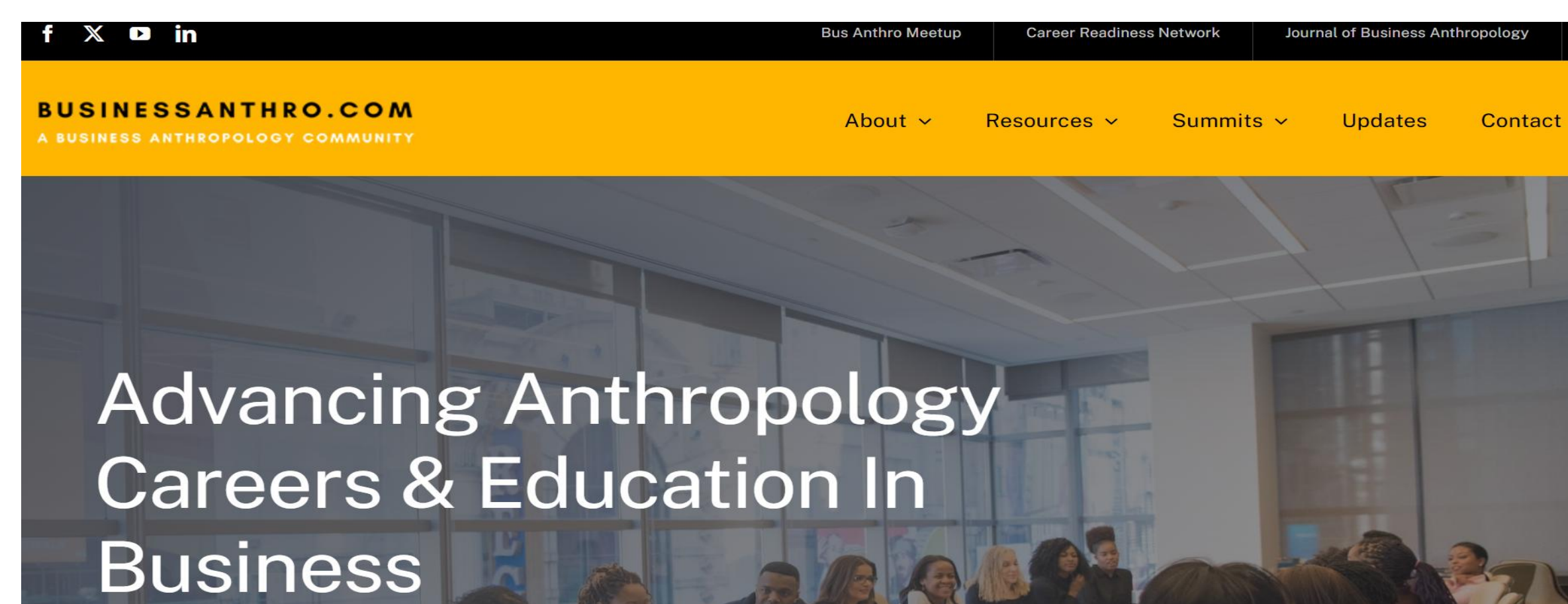
- How can ethnographic methods and anthropological perspectives be applied to address real-world business challenges and transform organizational culture while maintaining ethical integrity?
- In what ways do cultural values, norms, and rituals shape consumer behavior and influence marketing strategies?
- What role does business ethnography play in promoting diversity, equity, and inclusion in global and local workplaces?



A curated collection of essential works exploring the theory and practice of anthropology in business and corporate environments.

Selected References

- Cefkin, Melissa, ed. 2009. *Ethnography and the Corporate Encounter: Reflections on Research in and of Corporations*. New York: Berghahn Books.
 - Offers real-world case studies and ethical considerations for conducting ethnography in business settings.
- Jordan, Ann T. 2010. *Business Anthropology*. Long Grove, IL: Waveland Press.
 - Comprehensive overview of business anthropology concepts, organizational culture, and applied research methods.
- Sunderland, Patricia, and Rita Denny. 2007. *Doing Anthropology in Consumer Research*. Walnut Creek, CA: Left Coast Press.
 - A foundational text on applying ethnographic methods to marketing, product design, and consumer insight.
- Urban, Greg, and Kyung-Nan Koh. "Ethnographic Research on Modern Business Corporations." *Annual Review of Anthropology* 42 (2013): 139–58.
<http://www.jstor.org/stable/43049295>.
 - Analyzes the role of ethnographic research in understanding modern business practices within corporations.
- Wayman, E. R. "Consumer Anthropology." *Current Anthropology* 49, no. 2 (2008): 169–169. <https://doi.org/10.1086/524384>.
 - Discusses the application of anthropological methods to understand consumer behavior.



A platform dedicated to advancing careers and education in business anthropology through community, resources, and collaboration.

Course Outline—10 Weeks

Week 1	Introduction to Business Ethnography
Week 2	Ethnographic Methods
Week 3	Organizational Culture
Week 4	The Role of Business Ethnography In Marketing and Product Development
Week 5	Ethics and Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR)
Week 6	Consumer Culture
Week 7	Design Anthropology
Week 8	Industry Specific Ethnography
Week 9	Global Business
Week 10	Future Direction And Technology



A complete BM-800 microphone, and V8 sound card kit designed for professional-quality recording, streaming, and podcasting.

Final Project

- The final project is a group-produced podcast episode (10–15 minutes) that applies course concepts and ethnographic methods to a real-world business issue, case study, or industry-specific topic. Your episode should:
 - Clearly introduce the topic and its relevance to business ethnography.
 - Integrate insights from at least three course readings.
 - Include original content such as interviews, field observations, or commentary.
 - Demonstrate critical thinking, ethical awareness, and clear storytelling.
 - Be well-edited, with clear audio and proper attribution of all sources.
 - Podcasts will be presented during the final exam period, followed by a brief Q&A with the class. A written summary (500–700 words) outlining your process, key findings, and reflections on the experience must be submitted along with the audio file.